Is tutoring actually the right fit?

Before you sign up for a term — how to tell if the work is too hard, too easy, or just right, and what to ask any tutor on the phone.

You've probably seen this kitchen table.

Homework opens. Within ten minutes the mood has turned. By eight o'clock you're explaining the same concept for the third time and wondering if you're helping or doing it for them.

Or the flip side: they whip through the sheet, say tutoring is a waste of money, and still walk out of the exam with a mark that doesn't match what you know they can do.

Both patterns are common. Both are usually a **fit** problem — not a child who "isn't trying."

The one idea worth knowing

Children learn fastest on work they *almost* get — with a hint, a model, or someone asking the right question. Not with you doing it for them.

Psychologists call that band the Zone of Proximal Development (ZPD). You don't need the theory. You need to spot which band your child is in this week.

Three bands — which sounds like your house?

Too easy	Just right	Too hard (for now)
"This is boring." Done in minutes. Careless mistakes when it counts. Tutoring feels pointless.	"I need a hint… oh, I see it." Frustration, then a click. They can repeat it tomorrow with less help.	"I can't do this." Won't start. Meltdowns. You become the nightly tutor by default.

Good tutoring stays in the middle. Bad tutoring does the homework for them, or throws harder content at a gap that isn't closed yet.

Red flags

- Sessions are mostly "let's get tonight's sheet done"
- Your child can't explain what they practised without the tutor there
- Nobody tells you what to do for five minutes between visits
- The tutor can't say what should be different after five sessions
- Week six and the plan still changes every Thursday

What good support looks like

1. **Show one move** — "Watch how I'd start this."
2. **Hand it back** — "What's your first step?"
3. **Step away** — less help each week as the skill sticks.

If the tutor always holds the pencil, you're buying dependency.

Five questions before you pay for a term

1. "How will you figure out my child's level?" — not just subject and year.
2. "What should they do alone after session five that they can't do now?"
3. "What do you want me practising at home — specifically, for how long?"
4. "Are you still teaching in schools? What year levels?"
5. "Can we do one session before committing to a term?"

Why classroom-active tutors matter

"Experienced tutor" on a flyer often means "has tutored for years" — not "knows what your child's teacher is doing this term."

Why a term beats book-when-stuck

One-off homework rescue keeps everyone in fire-drill mode. A term gives room to find the gap, build one skill, and loop you in between visits.

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